

PART 4 OF 4 - SECTION FOUR: NOVEL

12TH HSC ENGLISH

MAHARASHTRA BOARD

QUICK NOTES - NOVEL

4.1 History of Novel

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4.1 History of Novel

About the Author

This is an expository chapter included in the textbook to trace the origin, growth and key forms of the novel as a literary genre; no individual author is credited.

About the Extract

A survey-style chapter that outlines how the novel emerged in the eighteenth century, traces its growth in England and India, and explains the essential elements and major types of the novel/novella.

Summary

The eighteenth century gifted English literature two entirely new forms without any trace in classical heritage - the Periodical Essay and the Novel. A novel is a relatively long narrative fiction in prose that describes intimate human experiences, embellished with details of time, place, people and their inner lives; the word derives from the Italian 'novella', meaning 'new'.

Early precursors include the Greek Romances (2nd-6th century), Murasaki Shikibu's 'Tale of Genji' (1010), often called the world's first novel, and Cervantes' 'Don Quixote' (1605-15), with which the European novel is said to begin. In England, after 1740, the rise of trade, the Industrial Revolution and a newly literate middle class created demand for realistic fiction about everyday life rather than aristocratic romance. Bunyan's 'Pilgrim's Progress' and Behn's 'Oroonoko' began the tradition, carried forward by Defoe, Swift, Richardson, Fielding, and later Dickens, Hardy, the Brontes, Austen, Woolf (pioneer of Stream of Consciousness), Agatha Christie, and 20th-century modernists like Forster, Joyce, Conrad and Orwell.

Indian Scenario: 'Rajmohan's Wife' by Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyaya was the first Indian English novel. Mulkraj Anand, R. K. Narayan and Raja Rao formed the founding trio, followed by Anita Desai, Nayantara Sahgal, Arun Joshi and Manohar Malgaonkar, then Amitav Ghosh, Vikram Seth and Upamanyu Chatterjee, and more recently Salman Rushdie, Arundhati Roy, Arvind Adiga, Kiran Desai and Kiran Nagarkar.

A Novella is shorter than a novel but longer than a short story, usually focused on one incident with one or two main characters (e.g. Conrad's 'Heart of Darkness', Melville's 'Billy Budd').

Elements of a Novel

Theme: the central idea or philosophical truth the writer conveys through the story.

Plot: the course of events built around internal or external conflict; may be simple or complex.

Character: the protagonist (main character) is set against an antagonist; depiction can range from a thumbnail sketch to a highly detailed portrait.

Setting: the background of place, period, time, climate and lifestyle in which the story unfolds.

Conflict: the struggle between opposing forces that creates interest and curiosity.

Language/Style: the vocabulary, tone and narrative technique an author uses to tell the story.

Theme / Message

The chapter builds an appreciation of the novel as literature's most dominant and adaptable genre. It shows how the form grew out of specific social and economic conditions, developed distinct sub-types (realistic, picaresque, historical, epistolary, Gothic, autobiographical, allegorical, utopian/dystopian, psychological, stream-of-consciousness, bildungsroman), and gave the Indian English novel its own rich tradition - equipping students to analyse fiction more critically.

Exam Practice Questions with Model Answers

Q1. What two literary forms did the eighteenth century gift to English literature? (2 marks)

The eighteenth century gave English literature two entirely new forms with no trace in classical heritage: the Periodical Essay and the Novel, both suited to the intellectual, sentimental and realistic spirit of the age.

Q2. What is a 'Novella'? Give one example. (2 marks)

A novella is a well-structured prose fiction shorter than a full novel but longer than a short story, usually focusing on one incident with one or two main characters; examples include Joseph Conrad's 'Heart of Darkness' and Hermann Melville's 'Billy Budd'.

Q3. Explain the origin and meaning of the term 'picaresque novel'. (2 marks)

The word 'picaresque' comes from the Spanish 'pícaro', meaning a rogue. A picaresque novel narrates, in episodic form, the adventures of an eccentric or disreputable protagonist.

Q4. Why could the newly educated middle class in eighteenth-century England find time to read and discuss novels? (2 marks)

Increased trade, commerce and the Industrial Revolution created an elite, educated middle class, and the spread of machines gave this class the leisure time needed for reading and discussing books.

Q5. Trace briefly the origin and growth of the English novel. (4 marks)

The novel's roots lie in the Greek Romances and works such as Murasaki Shikibu's 'Tale of Genji' and Cervantes' 'Don Quixote'. In England, after 1740, Bunyan's 'Pilgrim's Progress' and Behn's 'Oroonoko' began a tradition carried forward by Defoe, Swift and Richardson, and enriched across the centuries by Dickens, Hardy, the Bronte sisters, Jane Austen, Virginia Woolf and 20th-century modernists like Forster, Joyce and Orwell, who widened the genre into political, social and psychological territory.

Q6. Discuss the Indian tradition of the English novel. (4 marks)

The tradition began with Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyaya's 'Rajmohan's Wife', the first Indian English novel. Mulkraj Anand, R. K. Narayan and Raja Rao formed the founding trio, followed by Anita Desai, Nayantara Sahgal, Arun Joshi and Manohar Malgaonkar, then Amitav Ghosh, Vikram Seth and Upamanyu Chatterjee. Recent decades have seen the dazzling work of Salman Rushdie, Arundhati Roy, Arvind Adiga, Kiran Desai and Kiran Nagarkar.

Q7. Explain any four elements of a novel. (4 marks)

Theme is the central idea the writer conveys; Plot is the course of events shaped by internal or external conflict; Character depiction centres on a protagonist set against an antagonist; and Setting establishes the place, period and atmosphere in which the story unfolds. Together these elements, along with conflict and style, decide the overall texture of a novel.

4.2 To Sir, with Love, by E. R. Braithwaite

About the Author

Eustace Edward Ricardo Braithwaite (1912-2016), known as E. R. Braithwaite, was a Guyanese-born British-American novelist, writer, teacher and diplomat, best known for his stories of social conditions and racial discrimination against black people. Besides 'To Sir, with Love' (1959), his works include 'A Kind of Homecoming' and 'Reluctant Neighbors'.

About the Extract

'To Sir, with Love' is an autobiographical novel. The prescribed extract (Chapter 17) describes the half-yearly report of the Students' Council at Greenslade School, a rough London East End school where the narrator teaches.

Summary

An engineer by training, the narrator, Ricky Braithwaite, cannot find work after World War Two because he is black, and takes a teaching post at Greenslade School in London's East End. His students - rejects from other schools - bully and humiliate him at first. When scolding fails, Braithwaite changes tactics: he insists on treating the class as adults, addressing the girls as 'Miss' and asking to be called 'Sir'. The students gradually change their hygiene and attitudes, and Braithwaite takes them on cultural excursions, earning their respect and, along the way, a growing friendship with fellow teacher Gillian Blanchard. The novel is set against the backdrop of racism and colonial prejudice in post-war Britain, which Braithwaite experiences repeatedly outside the classroom.

Synopsis of the Extract: On 15th November, Greenslade School holds its half-yearly Students' Council report, entirely organised by the students. Head Mr Florian opens the proceedings; Miss Joseph and Denham preside. Each class reports on its term's work, the youngest first, showing a clear improvement in expression as the classes get older. Braithwaite's senior class reports last: Potter speaks on weights and measures, Sapiano on agricultural pests, Pegg and Jackson on geography, Dare and Fernman on physiology (Fernman produces a real skeleton for comic effect while making the point that 'basically all people were the same'), Dodd on the Reformation, and Denham on P.T. and games, which he calls 'ill-conceived and pointless'. In the question round that follows, the shy Miss Phillips calmly outwits Denham's protest, leaving Braithwaite deeply proud of his class's progress.

Character Sketch

Braithwaite (Narrator): patient, dignified and observant; wins his students' respect through calm persistence rather than authority, and takes quiet pride in their growth.

Denham: outspoken and critical, unafraid to challenge the school's policies, but gracious enough to accept defeat when out-argued.

Miss Joseph: responsible and articulate; co-presides over the Council with poise and explains its purpose clearly.

Fernman: theatrical and quick-witted, uses a prop skeleton to deliver both comic relief and a serious point about human equality.

Miss Phillips: outwardly frilly and quiet, but reveals sharp intelligence and confidence when she calmly defeats Denham's argument.

Theme / Message

The novel explores the teacher-student relationship, prejudice and racism in post-war Britain, and how respect, patience and innovative teaching can transform troubled students. The extract itself celebrates the 'interdependence of mankind' and shows how far Braithwaite's class has progressed in confidence, knowledge and maturity.

Exam Practice Questions with Model Answers

Q1. Which character in the extract is a teacher, and how do we know? (2 marks)

Miss Phillips is a teacher; she is shown seated with Mr Weston and Mrs Dale-Evans on the panel invited to answer students' questions, and calmly defends the school's P.T. policy when Denham challenges it.

Q2. Why did Braithwaite feel anxious as the turn of his class approached? (2 marks)

As the senior-most class, Braithwaite's students were reporting last, and he was eager to see whether they could match the standard of expression and confidence shown by the younger classes before them.

Q3. How did Fernman bring comic relief to the Students' Council programme? (2 marks)

Fernman had a model skeleton wheeled onto the stage on a gallows-like frame, which drew uproarious laughter, before turning serious to argue that regardless of race, 'the foundations were all laid out according to the same blue-print'.

Q4. What event takes place in the extract, and where is it held? (2 marks)

The half-yearly report of the Students' Council, held on 15th November in the school auditorium, is entirely arranged, presented and controlled by the students themselves.

Q5. Describe the question-answer session that concluded the Students' Council programme. (4 marks)

After all classes had reported, three teachers - Mr Weston, Mrs Dale-Evans and Miss Phillips - were picked at random by lottery to answer questions from the hall. Mr Weston blustered unconvincingly when Denham questioned the value of compulsory P.T., but the quiet Miss Phillips stepped in with a calm, confident answer that both defended the policy and left Denham unable to argue further, impressing the whole school.

Q6. Explain how the narrator played a role in bringing about a significant change in his students. (4 marks)

Faced with a disrespectful, unruly class, Braithwaite abandoned scolding and instead began treating his students as responsible adults, insisting on formal address and courtesy. He took them on cultural excursions many had never experienced, and patiently endured setbacks along the way. By the time of the Students' Council, his class showed marked improvement in confidence, articulation and cooperation, a transformation Braithwaite watches with visible pride during the reports.

Q7. Explain in brief the theme of the extract. (4 marks)

The extract centres on the idea of the interdependence of mankind, expressed through student reports linking mathematics, geography, physiology and history to global cooperation. At the same time, it dramatises the teacher-student bond, showing how far Braithwaite's once-difficult class has progressed under his guidance, and how a soft-spoken student like Miss Phillips can command real authority through preparation and calm confidence.

4.3 Around the World in Eighty Days, by Jules Verne

About the Author

Jules Gabriel Verne (1828-1905) was a French novelist, poet and playwright, widely considered a major literary figure in France and Europe and one of the most-translated authors in the world. His adventure novels include 'Journey to the Centre of the Earth' (1864), 'Twenty Thousand Leagues Under the Sea' (1870) and 'Around the World in Eighty Days' (1873).

About the Extract

The prescribed extract covers the novel's climax (Chapters XXXIV-XXXVII), in which Phileas Fogg, arrested and delayed at Liverpool, believes he has lost his wager - only to discover, through a twist involving the International Date Line, that he has won it after all.

Summary

At London's Reform Club, the precise and unflappable Phileas Fogg wagers twenty thousand pounds that he can travel around the world in just eighty days. Accompanied by his loyal French valet Passepartout, Fogg races through Brindisi, Suez, Bombay, Calcutta, Hong Kong, Yokohama, San Francisco, New York and Liverpool, overcoming one obstacle after another with quick thinking. Along the way he rescues and later falls in love with Aouda, an Indian princess. Detective Fix shadows Fogg throughout, suspecting him of a recent bank robbery and looking for a chance to arrest him.

Synopsis of the Extract: Fix finally arrests Fogg at Liverpool, and Fogg is briefly imprisoned, missing what he believes is his last chance to win the wager. When Fix learns the real robber has been caught, he releases Fogg, who rushes to London - but arrives, by his own reckoning, a day late. Believing he has lost everything, a depressed Fogg proposes marriage to Aouda regardless, and she happily accepts. As Passepartout dashes to fetch a clergyman, he discovers that, having travelled eastward around the globe, the party has actually gained a full day by crossing the International Date Line - meaning Fogg has won his bet after all, arriving at the Reform Club with seconds to spare.

Character Sketch

Phileas Fogg: precise, unemotional and honourable; motivated by honour rather than money, he grows through the journey to value human connection over solitary routine.

Passepartout: Fogg's loyal, resourceful French valet, whose quick wit and devotion repeatedly help the party out of trouble, and whose sharp eye finally solves the date puzzle that wins the wager.

Aouda: a rescued Indian princess whose courage and warmth win Fogg's affection; she brings emotional depth to his otherwise mechanical existence.

Detective Fix: dogged and suspicious; his mistaken pursuit of Fogg as a bank robber creates the novel's central obstacle and its ironic final delay.

Theme / Message

The novel's central theme is humanity's relationship with time - it can work for or against one's plans, and ultimately no one fully controls it. It also champions honour over money, quick thinking over despair, and shows how a rigid, solitary man is transformed by friendship and love over the course of his journey.

Exam Practice Questions with Model Answers

Q1. Why was Phileas Fogg arrested at Liverpool? (2 marks)

Detective Fix, convinced throughout the journey that Fogg was the man responsible for a recent bank robbery in London, finally arrested him at Liverpool just as the party reached England.

Q2. Why did Fogg believe he had lost the wager? (2 marks)

After being delayed by his arrest and eventually reaching London, Fogg calculated that he had arrived a day later than the eighty-day deadline required to win the bet.

Q3. How did Aouda respond when Fogg apologised for losing the wager? (2 marks)

Rather than reproaching him, Aouda proposed marriage to Fogg herself, and he joyfully accepted, showing that their relationship had grown to matter more to him than the bet.

Q4. What discovery allowed Fogg to win the wager after all? (2 marks)

Passepartout realised, while rushing to fetch a clergyman, that the date was a day earlier than the group had assumed - because travelling eastward around the world means gaining a full day when crossing the International Date Line.

Q5. Trace the sequence of events between Fogg's arrest and his winning of the wager. (4 marks)

Fix arrests Fogg at Liverpool on suspicion of bank robbery, and Fogg is imprisoned while Aouda and Passepartout wait anxiously. Fix soon learns the real robber has been caught and releases Fogg, who rushes by special train to London but believes he has arrived a day late. Despondent, he proposes to Aouda, who accepts; as Passepartout runs to arrange the wedding, he discovers it is actually a day earlier than assumed, and Fogg rushes to the Reform Club to win the bet with only seconds to spare.

Q6. Discuss the theme of time in 'Around the World in Eighty Days'. (4 marks)

The novel repeatedly shows time as fickle - it delays Fogg's party through missed connections, yet ultimately favours them through the gained day at the International Date Line. Verne's message is that no one can fully control time; it works the way it wants to, and humans are ultimately at its mercy, whether it appears to defeat or reward their plans.

Q7. What transformation does Phileas Fogg undergo over the course of the novel? (4 marks)

Fogg begins the novel as a solitary, mechanically precise man who cares little for how others perceive him. Through the challenges of the journey, his rescue of Aouda, and the loyalty of Passepartout, he comes to value human connection - love and friendship - above the wealth he could have doubled by winning the bet. By the end, honour, companionship and genuine feeling matter to him far more than money or reputation.

4.4 The Sign of Four, by Arthur Conan Doyle

About the Author

Sir Arthur Ignatius Conan Doyle (1859-1930) was a British writer best known for creating Sherlock Holmes. Originally a physician, he published 'A Study in Scarlet' in 1887, the first of four Holmes novels and more than fifty short stories that are considered milestones in crime fiction. 'The Sign of Four' (1890) is the second Holmes novel.

About the Extract

The prescribed extract covers Chapters II and III, 'The Statement of the Case', in which Mary Morstan narrates the mystery of her missing father and the strange pearls to Holmes and Watson.

Summary

Mary Morstan approaches Sherlock Holmes after her father vanished mysteriously ten years earlier, and after she began receiving a valuable pearl every year from an anonymous sender. A letter now summons her to a meeting, and Holmes and Watson agree to accompany her. They meet the eccentric Thaddeus Sholto, who reveals that Mary's father died the night he came to divide a hidden treasure with Thaddeus's father, Major Sholto - and that Mary is entitled to a share. Soon after, Thaddeus's brother Bartholomew is found murdered, the treasure gone, and Holmes traces the killers - the wooden-legged convict Jonathan Small and his companion Tonga - in a thrilling boat chase down the Thames. Small is captured and confesses the treasure's violent history, though the loot itself is lost in the river.

Synopsis of the Extract: In the Statement of the Case, Mary Morstan calmly recounts to Holmes and Watson how her father, Captain Morstan, disappeared after returning from India in 1878, how she has received a rare pearl every year since 1882 from an unknown benefactor, and how a letter has now arrived asking her to a meeting while warning her not to involve the police. Holmes listens closely, already forming deductions about the connection between Major Sholto's death and the mysterious pearls, while Watson finds himself increasingly drawn to Mary.

Character Sketch

Sherlock Holmes: brilliant, logical and endlessly observant; forms deductions from the smallest details and drives the investigation forward with calm authority.

Dr. Watson: loyal and warm-hearted; his growing affection for Mary Morstan adds an emotional thread to the detective plot.

Mary Morstan: composed, dignified and courageous despite her distressing circumstances; narrates her story clearly and becomes central to the mystery's resolution.

Jonathan Small: a wronged, embittered convict whose pursuit of the Agra treasure drives the novel's violence, ultimately proving that the treasure brings only ruin to all who seek it.

Theme / Message

The novel explores the corrupting power of greed - the Agra treasure brings death, betrayal and lifelong imprisonment to nearly everyone connected to it - alongside the triumph of reason and observation in unravelling a complex mystery, and a quieter theme of romance between Watson and Mary.

Exam Practice Questions with Model Answers

Q1. Why does Mary Morstan first visit Sherlock Holmes? (2 marks)

Mary seeks Holmes's advice about her father's mysterious disappearance ten years earlier and the strange annual gift of a valuable pearl she has received since 1882 from an unknown sender.

Q2. What instruction did the anonymous letter give Mary? (2 marks)

The letter asked Mary to come to a meeting accompanied by two friends, at the Lyceum Theatre, and specifically warned her not to bring the police.

Q3. What does Thaddeus Sholto reveal to Mary about her father's death? (2 marks)

Thaddeus reveals that Mary's father died of a sudden heart attack during a quarrel with Major Sholto over a hidden treasure, and that Mary is entitled to a share of that fortune.

Q4. How is Bartholomew Sholto's murder eventually solved? (2 marks)

Holmes deduces that two men were involved, one with a wooden leg; using a scent trail and a hired dog, he tracks the killers - Jonathan Small and Tonga - to their boat on the Thames and captures them after a chase.

Q5. Narrate briefly what Mary Morstan tells Holmes and Watson in the Statement of the Case. (4 marks)

Mary explains that her father, Captain Morstan, disappeared the night he was due to meet her at a London hotel after returning from India, and that no trace of him was ever found. Since 1882, she has received a valuable pearl by post every year from an anonymous sender, and has now received a letter summoning her to a meeting while instructing her to keep the police away, leading her to seek Holmes's help.

Q6. Discuss the theme of greed and its consequences in 'The Sign of Four'. (4 marks)

The Agra treasure brings only tragedy to those who pursue it: the Sheik's emissary and Bartholomew Sholto are both murdered for it, Tonga is shot while fleeing with it, Jonathan Small is sentenced to life imprisonment, and Major Sholto lives out his final years in guilt and paranoia. Even Mary Morstan, whose claim to the fortune first draws Holmes into the case, ultimately loses nearly all of it - the treasure's disappearance underscoring that its pursuit brought only ruin, not happiness, to everyone involved.

Q7. What role does Dr. Watson's growing affection for Mary Morstan play in the novel? (4 marks)

Alongside the detective plot, Watson's feelings for Mary provide the novel's romantic thread. His attraction begins the moment they meet, but he initially hesitates to pursue her while she stands to inherit a fortune, fearing he would appear to want her money. Once the treasure is lost in the Thames, this obstacle disappears, and Watson feels free to propose - showing how the treasure's loss, tragic for the mystery's other characters, clears the way for a happy personal resolution.

Quick Revision - Section Four (Novel)

Chapter	Author	Type	Core Theme
4.1 History of Novel	-	Informational/Expository	Origin, growth and elements of the novel
4.2 To Sir, with Love	E. R. Braithwaite	Novel (Autobiographical)	Teacher-student bond; racism and prejudice
4.3 Around the World in Eighty Days	Jules Verne	Novel (Adventure)	Mastery over time; honour over money
4.4 The Sign of Four	Arthur Conan Doyle	Novel (Mystery/Suspense)	Greed and its consequences; reason and detection

